MMUUSD



SPANISH IMMERSION

Program Handbook

2026-2027 School Year

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History

In 2015-16 a committee of parents, school board members, teachers and school administrators met to research and make a recommendation regarding a foreign language immersion program. They shared their findings in this white paper with the school board in February of 2016.

Further research was conducted over the summer of 2016 to address specific questions and presented in the Fall of 2016

In fall of 2017, we began our first year of immersion starting with a kindergarten class.Our program is

Year	South End	North End
2017-2018		Kindergarten
2018-2019		K-1
2019-2020		K-2
2020-2021	Kindergarten	K-3
2021-2022	K-1	K-4
2022-2023	K-2	K-5
2023-2024	K-3	K-5
2024-2025	K-4	K-5
2025-beyond	K-5	K-5

Mission

We at MMUUSD recognize language immersion education as a pathway for our students to become bilingual and biliterate, achieve academic excellence, and act as culturally competent citizens of the world.

Overview of Program

The MMUUSD Spanish Immersion program is a full one-way immersion program. A majority of students enter kindergarten with little to no Spanish background. In the formative years (K-2) students receive up to 90% of academic classroom instruction in Spanish. As students enter third grade and become increasingly bilingual, instruction in Spanish decreases and instruction in English increases.

Beginning in 2024 there will be a change that will ensure success for all Spanish Immersion students. Starting in kindergarten and continuing through second grade, English literacy instruction will now be included in the Spanish Immersion curriculum. This additional instruction will focus on English phonics using an explicit and systematic phonics program.

Grade	% academic instruction in Spanish
Kindergarten	80%
First	80%
Second	80%
Third	60%
Fourth	60%

Typical day

Students in the Spanish Immersion (K-4) learn in a typical class with one teacher in charge of all core academic areas. Students participate in morning meeting, academic instruction, and transitions in an immersive setting. Students attend lunch and recess with their peers in English classrooms. The class receives English instruction while attending daily unified arts classes (Physical Education, Art, Spanish, Music, Guidance, Library) .

Post-Spanish Immersion Program
Language Development Opportunities

The intent of the Spanish language development offerings after 5th grade are to prepare students to take higher level courses when they reach MMUHS, with the ultimate goal that students will take AP Spanish at some point during their time in high school. The middle school experience aims to build Spanish language speaking fluency, but also proficiency with reading and writing, which are critical for success in upper level high school Spanish courses. Furthermore, the middle school options were crafted within the strictures of the daily schedule and to ensure all students have equitable access to support resources (intervention, etc.).

Fifth Grade

In fifth grade, Spanish Immersion students will attend all core academic classes in English. For language instruction, students will have the following options:

- *Enroll in the world language exploratory seminar, in which students experience multiple languages throughout the year (1 Semester French, 1 Semester Spanish).*
- *Participate in an onsite custom Spanish language course that provides an emphasis on conversational speaking.*

Sixth Grade

For world language instruction, students will have the following options:

- Enroll in the world language exploratory seminar in which students experience multiple languages throughout the year (1 Semester French, 1 Semester Spanish).
- Participate in an onsite custom Spanish language course that provides an emphasis on conversational speaking.

Seventh Grade

For world language instruction, students will have the following options:

- Take French 1.
- Participate in an onsite custom Spanish language course that provides an emphasis on conversational speaking.

Eighth Grade

For world language instruction, students will have the following options:

- Continue with French 1.
- Take Spanish II/III (Onsite at CHMS/BRMS).
- *Spring of 8th grade year students will take a language proficiency assessment.*

Ninth through Twelfth Grade

Depending on student results from the language proficiency assessment in 8th grade, students will take a Spanish course at the level they are prepared for at MMUHS, e.g.:

- Take Spanish II, III, IV and/or AP.
- Continue with a new language offered at MMUHS.
- Dual enrollment at a local college or university (Only available after 10th grade).

Curriculum

The Spanish Immersion follows the same curriculum as all classes in the MMUUSD district. There are, however, specific differences due to language needs, especially in literacy. Students receive literacy instruction using the curriculum *American Reading Company Core.* Grounded in the science of reading, ARC Core® is designed to build strong knowledge and literacy in both English and Spanish, no matter the learning environment. Assessments occur in both English and Spanish to fully understand where each student is in their learning.

Spanish Language Proficiency

In the spring of 2020 the Spanish Immersion team created language assessments to better understand where students are in their Spanish development in three areas: presentational speaking, interpersonal communication, and listening. These assessments use the American Council on Teaching and Foreign Languages (ACTFL) Can-Do statements. The mission of integrating these assessments into the program is to better understand how students are progressing in their language acquisition and to plan for how to accommodate language needs into learning. After a pilot of assessing all students in the Spanish Immersion program, benchmarks were developed for each grade:

	Listening	**Interpersonal**	**Presentational**
Kindergarten	Novice mid	Novice low	Novice low
1st grade	Novice high	Novice mid	Novice mid
2nd grade	Intermediate low	Novice high	Novice high
3rd grade	Intermediate mid	Intermediate low	Intermediate low
4th grade	Intermediate high	Intermediate mid	Intermediate mid

Biliteracy Achievement Award

Upon their final year in elementary school (4th grade), children work on a portfolio to apply for the elementary Biliteracy Achievement Award. Learn more about the Biliteracy Achievement Award HERE.

Enrollment

Selection will be done through a lottery system and the number of spaces available within each school is proportional based on school enrollment. Class sizes will range from 15-20 students, which allows for balanced class sizes across the district. Below are the percentages of spaces available for each school based on current enrollment:

North: JES (67%) UCS (33%)

South: RES (61%) SMS (16%) BPMS (22%)

Any unused slots will go back into the lottery.

*Tuition opportunities will only be available should there be zero students on the waitlist.

Which program will I attend?
If you reside in the towns of Bolton, Huntington or Richmond, then your child can attend the South End Spanish Immersion Program located at Richmond Elementary School. If you reside in the towns of Jericho or Underhill, then your child can attend the North End Program located at Jericho Elementary School. If your child has a sibling already within the program, they will be prioritized and able to attend the school where their sibling is currently enrolled. Depending on enrollment, the district may offer the option of attending either the North or South in an effort to balance classroom sizes.

Lottery for Spanish-Speaking Families

In order to value, collaborate with, and honor our community members of Hispanic heritage, the Spanish Immersion Program will provide preference to children with Hispanic heritage for the kindergarten lottery. Children of one parent who is a native or heritage Spanish speaker (including biological non-custodial parents) are given priority for the kindergarten lottery process each spring. This policy enriches the experience for all students in the Spanish Immersion program by enhancing cultural connections and linguistic opportunities while honoring the contributions that our Hispanic families continue to make in the community.

Lottery for Siblings

Historically, if one child within a family was awarded a spot in the SI program via the lottery, any subsequent siblings were automatically provided entry into the SI program. This "sibling allowance" will be discontinued to ensure equal opportunities for all potential SI program lottery applicants. Moving forward, each sibling will need to go through the lottery process to enter the SI program. ***This change will be implemented for the Spring 2026 Spanish Immersion program lottery.***

To ensure equitable access to the Spanish Immersion program, students identified as "economically disadvantaged" (according to state provided data) will be provided preference (higher weighting) in the spring Spanish Immersion lottery process.

English Instruction

To ensure that all students can be successful in the Spanish Immersion program as they transition to a more bilingual classroom experience in third grade, we have intentionally increased the amount of English language instruction in grades K-2. Specifically, students will receive explicit phonics instruction starting in kindergarten. When students progress to third grade, there will be English instruction on all five components of reading (phonics, phonemic awareness, fluency, vocabulary, & comprehension). Furthermore, all SI students will be given both English and Spanish STAR early literacy/reading screeners so as to provide additional data for classroom teachers and interventionists regarding student proficiency levels.

Grade Level	ELA Instructional Component	Duration
Kindergarten	Emphasis on phonics & phonemic awareness with cross linguistic transfer	30 minutes, 5x/week
First Grade	Emphasis on phonics & phonemic awareness with cross linguistic transfer	30 minutes, 5x/week
Second Grade	Emphasis on phonics & phonemic awareness with cross linguistic transfer	30 minutes, 5x/week
Third Grade	All components	90 minutes, 5x/week *(Two units for 16 weeks)*
Fourth Grade	All components	90 minutes, 5x/week *(Two units for 16 weeks)*

FAQ

How does special education and intervention work?
All students are welcome into the program. If your child is currently on an IEP and you have any questions regarding your child, we recommend reaching out to your child's case manager. We have a Spanish speaking interventionist who works with students in both Jericho Elementary and Richmond Elementary.

Can we try it out and withdraw at any time?
Recognizing that this is a highly sought after program, in our experience one thing is very consistent and that is the need for long-term commitment to the program. The impact of an immersion program takes years to build and thus a commitment to being in the program long-term is important for potential students.

How quickly will my child acquire Spanish?
Language learning is a complex process that requires time and experience. Throughout Kindergarten and First Grade, students begin building strong foundational skills in comprehension and begin speaking in words, phrases and eventually sentences. In Second and Third Grade, the classes focus on producing Spanish in conversations, presentations and writing. Once children exit the program in fifth grade, they have strong Spanish skills in all areas.

Does my child receive Unified Arts classes in Spanish?
All of our Unified Arts (Physical Education, Music, Art, Guidance) in English.

Will my child have the opportunity to interact with other students in the English classes?
Spanish Immersion classes are integrated into all other parts of the school. Students eat lunch, do recess, celebrations and special events with their English peers.

Why Spanish?
The district planning team considered multiple languages and after researching and weighing options, they chose Spanish for several reasons. The primary reason is the availability of resources, both curriculum and books, that are available in Spanish. Another reason is that Spanish is the second most commonly spoken language in the United States.

What is the language background of the teachers?
We have a mix of native and non native Spanish speaking classroom teachers, interventionists, and paraprofessionals. During our search, teachers are asked to answer questions in Spanish and complete a writing sample.

Can my child enter the program after Kindergarten?
Children who are able to demonstrate grade-level proficiency through our Spanish assessments may enter the program in grades 1-4, dependent on vacant slots. This allows children who enter the school district with Spanish proficiency to continue their academic growth in the language and further strengthen the Spanish Immersion community. The program will only assess families who have secured housing in the district and are able to enroll in MMUUSD.

What does MTSS look like in Spanish Immersion? You can read about our specific Spanish Immersion MTSS plan here.